Parshas Toldos

Digging Beneath the Surface

Mesorah and What We Bring Forward · Digging for Torah · The Partnership of Yitzchak and Rivka · Bechirah and Our Kochos

I. Toldos: What We Bring Forward

Parshas Toldos is one of the foundational parshiyos of Sefer Bereishis. It is not the most action-filled parsha, and yet within its stories lie some of the deepest lessons about who we are, where we come from, and what it means to be a partner with HaKadosh Baruch Hu in the world He has made. It opens with a pasuk that seems, at first, simply to repeat itself:

ואלה תולדת יצחק בן אברהם אברהם הוליד את יצחק

"These are the generations of Yitzchak, son of Avraham. Avraham fathered Yitzchak."
— Bereishis 25:19

Why does the Torah tell us in one breath that Yitzchak was the son of Avraham, and then that Avraham fathered Yitzchak? Rashi explains that there were scoffers of the generation who cast doubt on Yitzchak's parentage, and so Hashem formed the features of Yitzchak's face in the likeness of Avraham, so that all would see and say plainly that Avraham had fathered Yitzchak. But there is a further lesson folded into this opening. The word toldos is not only a record of who gave birth to whom. It is the Torah's way of raising the question of mesorah, of what one generation receives and what it brings forth into the next. Avraham brought Yitzchak into the world. The question the parsha now asks is what Yitzchak would bring into the world in turn, how he would take up his father's legacy, develop it, and carry the partnership with Hashem forward. Where are we coming from, and what are we bringing forward? That is the question of our own toldos as well.

II. Digging for Torah

To feel the answer, we turn to one of the stranger episodes of the parsha: Yitzchak and his wells. Yitzchak settles in Gerar, grows prosperous and powerful, and is eventually sent away by Avimelech because his strength had grown too great. And through all of it, the Torah keeps returning to the image of Yitzchak digging, opening wells, going down into the earth in search of water. It is a curious thing to dwell on at such length, until we remember what Chazal teach:

אין מים אלא תורה

"There is no water except Torah."
— Bava Kamma 82a

Water sustains the body, and Torah sustains the neshamah, and just as water can lie hidden far beneath the surface of the ground, the Torah holds depths that give themselves up only to effort, to commitment, and to perseverance. Read this way, Yitzchak's wells become a portrait of our whole relationship with Torah. He is forever digging. He never assumes that because a well has been filled in, the water below it is gone. He knows there is something beneath the surface worth uncovering, and he gives himself no permission to stop. This is a

beautiful reminder of what our mission is. We are never granted leave to step away from Torah, to stop searching, to stop reaching for Hashem and for His ratzon. This is Hashem's world and Hashem's reality, and we are guests within what He desires. To live with that awareness is to keep digging deeper, to keep looking, to keep searching for the Torah that waits just beneath the surface of everything around us.

III. The Water Is Ours

But there is another party at these wells, and they do something strange. The Pelishtim go to the wells that Avraham's servants had dug, and they stop them up and fill them with earth. Yitzchak digs them open again, and then the quarrels begin:

ויריבו רעי גרר עם רעי יצחק לאמר לנו המים ויקרא שם הבאר עשק כי התעשקו עמו

"The shepherds of Gerar quarreled with Yitzchak's shepherds, saying, the water is ours. And he named the well Esek, because they had contended with him."
— Bereishis 26:20

There is nothing extra in the Torah, not a word and not a letter, and so we have to ask what this is doing here. For there is a contradiction built into it. First the Pelishtim fill the wells with earth, making their water inaccessible, declaring in effect that there is nothing there to be found. And then, the moment Yitzchak's servants strike water, those same people turn and insist that the water is theirs. They block the source and claim what flows from it in the same breath. It is a double message, and it is one we meet again and again in the world. There are those who first cover a thing over, who say that what we are looking for is not really there, and who then turn around and say that it was theirs all along.

Yitzchak does not answer this with an argument. He answers it the only way that matters. He keeps digging. He names the first contested well Esek, after the contention, and digs another; and when there is strife over that one too, he names it Sitnah; and he digs again, until at last he reaches a well over which there is no quarrel at all:

ויקרא שמה רחבות ויאמר כי עתה הרחיב ה׳ לנו ופרינו בארץ

"He called its name Rechovos, saying, Now Hashem has made room for us, and we shall be fruitful in the land."
— Bereishis 26:22

Yitzchak persists until the water can flow without opposition. He does not merely argue over the wells. He digs them, and through the digging he makes their water available once again.

IV. When the World Rediscovers Our Wells

I had an experience at work that brought this whole idea into focus. One of the most senior executives in the company came to run a sales training, and he spoke about consciousness and awareness, about how a person's inner emotional state shapes the way he interacts with everyone around him. He drew on various philosophical traditions, quoting figures like Gandhi and Buddha, to speak about optimism, self-awareness, and living from a higher emotional state. This person is not Jewish, and he is entitled to learn from whatever sources he wishes. But as he spoke, I burst out laughing. Not disrespectfully, and not because there was anything wrong with what he was teaching; we have a good relationship, and, Baruch Hashem, I was not fired for laughing during a C-level executive's presentation.

When he asked what I found so funny, I explained. For many years I have been zocheh to learn with Rabbi Gerzi, and the ideas he was presenting as profound discoveries were the very basics of what we learn. He spoke of living from a higher emotional state, and we would call that aliyas hamiddos, the elevation of our character. He spoke of the lower states and behaviors, and we would call that kilkul hamiddos, the deterioration of those same middos. He spoke of awareness, and we speak constantly of living with daas, of seeing what is happening around us and within us and weighing our responses to it. He was uncovering, in his own language, water that had been in our wells all along.

The Torah's concern with these things reaches all the way back. When the animals enter the teivah in Parshas Noach, the Torah does not use the short, blunt word for an impure animal. It takes the longer way around:

הבהמה אשר איננה טהרה

"The animal that is not pure."
— Bereishis 7:8

The Gemara explains that the Torah deliberately lengthened its wording here to teach us never to let a coarse expression leave our mouths; even the words we choose are part of our avodah (Pesachim 3a). The way we speak, and think, and carry ourselves in the world is itself Torah. So when another tradition arrives, by its own road, at an idea that is already ours, the lesson is not simply to insist that the water is ours and leave it at that. The lesson is to remember that the water is there, to recognize its worth, and to make the effort to uncover it ourselves. Yitzchak did not win the wells by arguing over them. He won them by digging.

V. Yitzchak and Rivka: A Partnership

The wells show us Yitzchak's particular koach. He is gevurah, the strength to hold a direction, to withstand pressure, to keep digging without letting every confrontation consume him. And yet, when we return to the opening of the parsha, we find that even Yitzchak could not fulfill his mission alone. For twenty years he and Rivka were married without children, and the entire future, the continuation of Avraham's mesorah, seemed to hang on something they could not accomplish by their own strength:

ויעתר יצחק לה׳ לנכח אשתו כי עקרה הוא ויעתר לו ה׳ ותהר רבקה אשתו

"Yitzchak entreated Hashem opposite his wife, for she was barren; and Hashem allowed Himself to be entreated by him, and Rivka his wife conceived."
— Bereishis 25:21

Rashi explains the words lenochach ishto, opposite his wife, with an image of great beauty: this one stood in one corner and prayed, and that one stood in another corner and prayed. Both of them were davening, two people from utterly different worlds joined in a single purpose. Yitzchak had grown up in the home of Avraham and Sarah; Rivka had come out of a house of deceit and avodah zarah and had chosen, by her own will, to leave it all behind. And Rashi adds a line that must be handled with care, that the tefillah of a tzaddik who is the child of a tzaddik is not like the tefillah of a tzaddik who is the child of a rasha, which is why the pasuk says that Hashem was entreated by him. This takes nothing away from Rivka, who was an extraordinary tzaddekes in her own right. It points, rather, to the meeting of two different kinds of strength, and it brings us back to a truth we have been following across all of Bereishis:

לא טוב היות האדם לבדו אעשה לו עזר כנגדו

"It is not good for man to be alone; I will make him a helper corresponding to him."
— Bereishis 2:18

A wife is not merely one who helps her husband carry out what he has already decided to do. The word is ezer kenegdo, a helper who stands opposite him, and Chazal hear in it both help and resistance. She is a partner in discovering what needs to be done in the first place. Yitzchak holds the steadfast strength of Avraham's mesorah, the gevurah that digs and holds its ground. Rivka brings a strength shaped in a harder world and forged by the choices she made to leave it, and she can see what Yitzchak, in his steadiness, might not. In the way we are developing this, she is also the one who presses him toward what he is capable of, who can say, in effect, do not be so much of a tzaddik that you forget there are mitzvos to be done. There is a time to sit and dig deeper and deeper into Torah for its own sake. But the goal was never only to draw the water up for ourselves. It was to make sure the world could drink, that Torah could be lived and used in a healthy way. And that is where the partnership becomes so beautiful: Yitzchak has his kochos and Rivka has hers, and together they accomplish what neither of them, alone, would have accomplished in quite the same way.

VI. Yaakov, Esav, and Bechirah

From that partnership come Yaakov and Esav, and with them the Torah raises one of its most searching questions. Already in the womb, Rivka feels a struggle within her:

ויתרצצו הבנים בקרבה ותאמר אם כן למה זה אנכי ותלך לדרש את ה׳

"The children struggled within her, and she said, if so, why am I like this? And she went to seek Hashem."
— Bereishis 25:22

Rashi, citing the Midrash, explains the struggle: when Rivka passed the tents of Torah, Yaakov strained to come out, and when she passed a place of avodah zarah, Esav strained to come out. Already before birth, each was drawn toward a different world. This week I was speaking with a friend about this teaching, and he raised a sharp and honest question. If Yaakov and Esav were pulled so powerfully in opposite directions before they had even drawn a breath, where is their bechirah chofshis, their free choice? If one child is bent toward Torah by his very nature and the other toward avodah zarah, what choice does either of them truly have? It is a profound question, because each of us does enter the world with inclinations we never chose, drives and desires and difficulties that were simply given to us. One person finds tremendous pleasure in a piece of Chassidus; another has a powerful taivah pulling him elsewhere. None of us selected the nature we began with.

What I suggested to my friend is that this is not where bechirah disappears. It is precisely where bechirah becomes real. Free choice was never meant to be a choice between two things when only one of them holds any appeal. The real test comes exactly when we can feel the pull of something, recognize its attraction, sense the genuine strength or value in it, and still decide how we will respond. We have the ability to turn away from a path we should not walk even when something in it calls to us, and to choose the Torah, the ratzon Hashem, even when an easier road would satisfy the desire of the moment. The existence of an inclination has never, by itself, determined how a person must act. There is a difference between what we are drawn to and what we choose to pursue, between possessing a koach and deciding how that koach will be used.

We see it in the brothers themselves. Esav grows into a man of the field, a hunter, a figure of restless physical strength, while Yaakov is described in quieter words:

ויעקב איש תם ישב אהלים

"And Yaakov was a wholesome man, dwelling in tents."
— Bereishis 25:27

Yet Yaakov's quiet does not mean weakness. In the parshiyos ahead he will stand against Lavan, endure years of hardship, and wrestle a malach until the dawn. And Esav's strength does not mean he was without good. The question the Torah presses is never which brother was born stronger or with which inclination. The question is what each of them chose to do with what he was given.

VII. The Bechorah: Now, or the Future

Nowhere does this become clearer than in the sale of the bechorah. Esav comes in from the field exhausted and hungry, and Yaakov has a pot of lentils before him. Esav wants to eat, now, and Yaakov sees in the moment an opportunity to acquire the birthright of the firstborn, with everything it carries for the future. Esav agrees, and the Torah renders its quiet verdict:

ויבז עשו את הבכרה

"And Esav despised the birthright."
— Bereishis 25:34

The deepest difference between the brothers is not that one loves food and the other loves spiritual responsibility. It is in how they weigh what matters. Esav stands before an immediate desire and a future responsibility, and he chooses the hunger in front of him at the price of something far greater. This is the very challenge we face without end. How often do we surrender something of real value tomorrow because something lesser calls to us today? How often do we choose the easy over the meaningful, failing to see that the worth of an action may not show itself until much later? Yitzchak's wells teach us to dig beneath the surface; Yaakov's bechorah teaches us to look beyond the present moment. Both ask us to recognize that what is most valuable is rarely what is most immediately visible.

VIII. Even Esav Had Something to Teach

And yet it would be too easy to close the story by saying that we must all simply become Yaakov and reject everything of Esav, for that would miss something the Torah wants us to see. Esav had koach. He had strength and ability and the capacity to act, and though he so often failed to direct them well, that does not mean there was no good in him. In one mitzvah in particular, kibbud av, the honoring of a father, Esav reached a height that Chazal hold up with astonishment:

מימי לא שמשתי את אבא כמו שעשה עשו

"Never in my life did I serve my own father as Esav served his."
— Bereishis Rabbah 65:16

These are the words of Rabban Shimon ben Gamliel, one of the greatest of our Chachamim, who explained that whereas he would attend to his father in ordinary clothes, Esav would

dress in royal garments to serve Yitzchak, for he felt that nothing less was fitting to honor his father. Think about what it means that a man whose choices the Torah so often condemns possessed a quality our own leaders looked upon with awe. It does not excuse his wrongdoing or soften the consequences of his path. But it teaches something essential: a person can hold tremendous kochos and still fail to direct them rightly, and even someone whose overall direction is badly mistaken may carry a particular strength from which we have everything to learn. This is the measure the Mishnah gives us:

איזהו גבור הכובש את יצרו

"Who is mighty? One who conquers his inclination."
— Pirkei Avos 4:1

True gevurah is not the mere possession of strength. It is the power to direct it. The one born with great force may be tested in restraint; the one who loves to learn may be tested in carrying that learning out beyond the walls of the beis midrash; and the one for whom a part of avodas Hashem comes hard may reveal his greatness precisely in the effort it costs him. We are not all given the same starting point, and we are not all Yaakov. But each of us is given the ability, and the responsibility, to choose what we do with the kochos that are ours.

IX. Who Am I Today?

All of this carries us back to where the parsha began. Avraham brought Yitzchak into the world, and Yitzchak and Rivka brought Yaakov and Esav into theirs. But toldos is not only about the children we bring into being. It is also about what we bring forth through our choices. Every time we dig deeper into Torah, every time we encourage another person toward what he is capable of, every time we feel an inclination pulling us from our responsibilities and choose otherwise, we bring something into the world that was not quite there before. We take the kochos Hashem has given us and use them to take part in His creation. This is the partnership we have been tracing across all of Sefer Bereishis: Hashem makes the world, and then gives us the privilege of helping to shape what it can yet become. He does not ask us all to be identical. He asks each of us to turn what we have been given toward His ratzon.

And so, as we enter Shabbos, perhaps the question of Parshas Toldos is simply this: who am I today? Am I being Yitzchak, digging beneath the surface, refusing to give up when the wells are stopped up, searching still for the Torah Hashem has hidden for me to find? Am I being Rivka, recognizing the abilities of the people around me and pressing them, gently, toward what Hashem wants of them? Am I being Yaakov, running toward Torah and the value of the future, unwilling to trade what truly matters for the satisfaction of a moment? And can I even learn from Esav, recognizing the power of strength and initiative and the devotion of his kibbud av, while taking care to direct such strengths toward the ratzon of Hashem? We are not all given identical kochos, and we are not all asked to accomplish the same things in the same way. But we are each given the chance to choose, to grow, to recognize what Hashem has placed within us, and to use it well.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos.

Reflection Questions

- *Where am I treating a filled-in well as though the water were gone, giving up on a piece of Torah, or on a person, because the surface shows nothing?*
- *What did I receive in my own mesorah, and what am I actually bringing forward from it into the next generation?*
- *Am I so absorbed in digging Torah for myself that I have forgotten to make it live in the world around me?*
- *Who is the ezer kenegdo in my life pressing me toward what I am capable of, and am I letting them, or resisting?*
- *Where do I tell myself "this is simply my nature," when the real bechirah is choosing how I respond to the pull I feel?*
- *Like Esav's kibbud av, what strength in myself, or in someone I am quick to dismiss, could be turned toward the ratzon of Hashem?*